ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
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PART THREE

The Road

How is it walked?

The road covers no distance; it removes the veils inside us, in four stages that come in order. Two are ours: polishing the self with the law, and emptying the heart of everything but God. Two are God’s: adorning the emptied heart, and the passing away of the false self.

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إِلٰهِي وَأَلْهِمْنِي وَلَهاً بِذِكْرِكَ إِلَىٰ ذِكْرِكَ

My Lord, inspire me with a passionate love of remembering You so that I may keep on remembering You.

Munajat Sha‘baniyyah

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The stages of the journey

يَا قَرِيباً لاَ يَبْعُدُ عَنِ ٱلْمُغْتَرِّ بِهِ

You Near One, Who is not far from one who is away from You.[1]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

Many of us save for years to travel to Makka, Najaf, or Karbala. That journey is measured in miles. The line above, from the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah (a prayer of the month of Shaʿban), speaks of another journey. It calls God the Near One, who is not far even from the one who is away from Him.

If God is near even to the one who is away from Him, something on our side must make a person "away". Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali, the supplication Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as) taught for the nights of Ramadan, names it. It first says that whoever travels towards God has only a short way to go[2]. Then it says what stands in the way.

[1] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §80.

[2] *Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §46.

وَأَنَّكَ لاَ تَحْتَجِبُ عَنْ خَلْقِكَ إِلاَّ أَنْ تَحْجُبَهُمُ ٱلأَعْمَالُ دُونَكَ

You do not conceal Yourself against Your creatures unless their evildoings stand between them and You.[3]

Du'a Abu Hamza al-Thumali

God conceals Himself from no one. What keeps a person away is their own wrong deeds, which stand between them and Him like a veil. The journey to God removes what stands between, and it has an order of its own. This chapter sets out the stages of the journey: why it covers no distance, what its four stages are, and why they come in order.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *hijab* (plural *hujub*): a veil between the heart and God · *suluk*: wayfaring; the journey to God · *salik*: the wayfarer · *tajliya*: polishing the self through the law · *takhliya*: emptying the heart of all but God · *tahliya*: the adornment of the heart with God's gifts · *fana'*: passing away; the loss of the sense of self before God

Nearer than the jugular vein

The journey covers no distance because God is already near. Surah Qaf says this of every human being. God created him and knows what his soul whispers to him, and the verse ends with these words.

وَنَحْنُ أَقْرَبُ إِلَيْهِ مِنْ حَبْلِ ٱلْوَرِيدِ ﴿١٦﴾

And We are nearer to him than his jugular vein.

Qur'an 50:16

Few things are closer to a person than the vein in their own neck, and God is nearer than that. A traveller towards Him has no distance to cross.

With no distance to cross, the journey runs inward. The mystics call it wayfaring (*suluk*), and the one who travels is the wayfarer (*salik*). The Arabic word for wayfaring also means a person's conduct, the way they carry themselves through life. Sheikh Bahmanpour describes the journey simply. "We are not traveling from one place to another place. We are actually finding ourselves."

[3] *Du'a Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §47–48.

Its purpose is to see what is already around us: the presence of God and our own selves.

The inward journey removes a veil. In the lectures, the journey means lifting the veil that blocks the heart's vision and keeps the light of God from shining in it. The many methods the mystics have devised serve this one aim. It is the journey we were created for, since human beings were made to see the glory and beauty of Allah, and it is the veil over the heart that stops them.

The veils are not all of one kind. The mystics speak of dark veils and veils of light, and the stages of the journey deal with them differently.

Dark veils are the ones we make ourselves. Our own actions create them, and they belong to the lower self (*nafs*). This is what Duʿa Abu Hamza means when it says that God conceals Himself from no one unless their wrong deeds stand between them and Him. Each wrong act lays a dark layer over the heart, and a heart under such layers cannot see Allah.

Veils of light are finer, and we do not make them. They belong to the higher levels of the soul, the heart (*qalb*) and the spirit (*ruh*). They come from our existence as creatures, not from anything we do. The outer veils of light lift at the end of the journey this chapter describes. Some never lift, even between the Prophet ﷺ and God, because without them creation would perish before the glory of Allah.

Whatever the kind of veil, the hindrance lies on our side, not God's. In the lectures' words, "There is no hindrance from the other side, the hindrance is inside us; we have to remove it." The journey therefore covers no distance. It removes the veils inside us that can be lifted, first the dark ones our deeds have made and then the outer veils of light.

Four stages: two ours, two God's

The veils come off in stages, and the mystics count four of them to the end of the soul's first journey towards God. In English they are polishing, emptying, adorning, and passing away. Each of the next four chapters takes one stage in full, so the aim here is only to see the whole road in order.

The first stage is polishing (*tajliya*), from a word for burnishing something until it shines. What is polished is the body and the lower self. The stage opens when a person wakes from heedlessness and repents, not only of sins but of

taking everything for granted. It continues in doing whatever the Prophet ﷺ asked. The obligatory and recommended acts are done, the forbidden and the disliked are avoided, and the Qur'an and the Sunna are followed "in the strictest sense". Polishing begins the work on the dark veils our deeds have made. It is the subject of Chapter Nine.

The second stage is emptying (*takhliya*). Here the work moves from the outward acts to the heart, which must be cleared of every "occupation other than Allah". Outward practice is the easier part, whereas what occupies the heart is harder to remove. A person can give up wine without much difficulty, but giving up evil thoughts about other people is another matter. The mystics teach five disciplines: silence, hunger, night vigil, seclusion, and remembrance. This book treats them as the tools of this stage, since each is a recommended act aimed at the heart. Chapter Ten takes them in turn.

The third stage is adorning (*tahliya*). Once the self is polished and the heart emptied, the soul is adorned from the spiritual world with what no effort of its own could make. The mystics speak of visions, of inspirations, and of a deeper understanding of the Qur'an. One of these gifts is the love of God. No one can create it in themselves; God places it in a heart that has been purified. Chapter Eleven follows love as it carries the traveller on.

The fourth stage is passing away (*fana'*). When adorning reaches its height, God shows the traveller a glimpse of His glory, "at a very low level" as the lectures put it. Before it the traveller loses the perception of self, and with it all selfishness. The soul is still there, and so is the individual. Sayyid Haydar Amuli calls the station of passing away "the last of the levels and the highest of the stations of the path"[4]. Passing away is coupled with remaining (*baqa'*), and on the right path it is followed by a sober return. Chapter Twelve explains both.

The four stages fall into two pairs. The first two are the traveller's work: the law is kept, and the heart is guarded against whatever occupies it. The last two are God's act on the heart the traveller has prepared. In the lectures' image, the traveller prepares the soul for the food that God gives it. Of adorning they say, "It is Allah's act on the soul", and add that it comes not directly but through

[4]Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 195.

the angels around us. No effort brings about the sight of His glory either. The box below sets the four stages side by side.

⧗ THE ROAD AT A GLANCE

Stage	What happens
1. Polishing (*tajliya*). Ours. Chapter Nine.	Wake, repent, and keep the law strictly, starting with the rights of people. The work on the dark veils of our deeds begins.
2. Emptying (*takhliya*). Ours. Chapter Ten.	Clear the heart of every occupation but God. ʿIrfan proper begins here. This book reads the five disciplines as its tools: silence, hunger, night vigil, seclusion, and remembrance.
3. Adorning (*tahliya*). God's. Chapter Eleven.	God's gifts to the emptied heart: insight, understanding of the Qur'an, and love, which carries the traveller until even love is left at the door.
4. Passing away (*fana'*). God's. Chapter Twelve.	Shown a glimpse of God's glory, the traveller loses the sense of self. On the right path he comes back sober, seeing God in all things.

There are therefore four stages to the end of the first journey. Two are ours, polishing and emptying, and two are God's, adorning and passing away.

In order, and none dropped

The four stages come in a fixed order, because each needs the one before. The Shia mystics hold that until the soul and body have been polished with what the law asks, "you cannot move to the next step". The gifts God gives in adorning are all around us, yet only a purified soul can catch them. The mystics see and hear what others cannot, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "not because ... they are chosen ones but because they have furbished their souls". Passing away comes last. It happens when adorning reaches its height, when God shows a glimpse of His glory to a heart already adorned.

None of the stages is dropped when the next begins. The lectures say this of polishing, which "should accompany a mystic until the end". Even the Prophet ﷺ, at the highest of stations, was told to stand vigil through the night and recite the Qur'an in a measured tone (Q 73:1–4). As Chapter Six showed, no station on the road releases the traveller from the law, and once the truth is unveiled the law is kept more carefully, not less. This book draws a wider point from it. Each stage is added to those before it, so a traveller who has reached adorning is still polishing the self.

Since the first stage is the law, any believer can already start on the road. The lectures say this of polishing, and they place the start of 'irfan proper at the second stage. 'Irfan proper means the deeper understanding the mystics seek, and it begins when the work turns from the outward acts to the heart.

> ⧗ **HISTORY: A PHILOSOPHER'S LADDER**
>
> Ibn Sina was mainly a philosopher, not a mystic, yet in his *al-Isharat*, which appears to be his last work, he gave a whole section to the stations of the 'urafa'[5]. His count begins with will (*irada*), the longing to return to God, and training (*riyada*), which clears the path of all but God[6]. When these reach a certain degree, flashes of God's light descend on the traveller, "momentary like flashes of lightning appearing and instantly vanishing"[7]. Sheikh Bahmanpour, reading the passage with his students, adds that the light comes at first from behind the clouds, because the heart could not yet bear it uncovered. With more training the flashes become "a prolonged blaze" and a lasting state[8]. At arrival the traveller "becomes oblivious to his own self and views only the Holy"[9]. Khwaja Nasir al-Din al-Tusi, commenting on the *Isharat*, counts nine stages in three groups of three, for the beginning, the way, and arrival[10]. The numbers differ, but the order is close to this chapter's. Will and training come first, the flashes come once training reaches a certain degree, and arrival comes last[11].

The journey to God therefore covers no distance. It removes veils inside us in four stages. Polishing and emptying are ours; adorning and passing away are God's. Each stage rests on the one before, and none is dropped when the

[5] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.
[6] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 46–47.
[7] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 48.
[8] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 48.
[9] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 49.
[10] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 50.
[11] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 46–49.

next begins. Together they complete only the first of four journeys the mystics describe, from creation to God[12] the return that follows belongs to Chapters Twelve and Sixteen.

The first stage asks for the law before anything else, so a believer need not wait for a teacher to begin, though a teacher helps to say which of the recommended acts matter most. Its first step is one any believer can take. What is it?

> **➤ TRY THIS**
>
> Mirza ʻAli Aqa Qadi, the teacher of ʻAllama Tabataba'i, had beginners recite the Musabbihat every night before sleep for a whole year, and only then gave them a second instruction. These are the surahs that open with God's glorification, among them al-Hadid, al-Hashr, al-Saff, al-Jumuʻa, and al-Taghabun. Al-Kafi records Imam Muhammad al-Baqir (as) naming six, these five and al-Aʻla, and saying that whoever recites the six before sleep will live to see the reign of Imam al-Mahdi (atfs), and at death will be placed near the Prophet ﷺ[13]. It is a recommended act of the kind that polishing is made of. Tonight, begin with one of them before you sleep. If you can, keep it up each night, and add the others as the habit settles.

[12] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 49.

[13] Shaykh ʻAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 1036.

9

Polishing: setting out

إِلٰهِي وَقَدْ أَفْنَيْتُ عُمْرِي فِي شِرَّةِ ٱلسَّهْوِ عَنْكَ وَأَبْلَيْتُ شَبَابِي فِي سَكْرَةِ ٱلتَّبَاعُدِ مِنْكَ

My Lord, I have wasted my life committing the crime of forgetting You and played havoc with my youth, intoxicated with keeping myself away from You.[14]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

After the daily prayer, many of us ask God's forgiveness (*istighfar*) with the word *astaghfirullah*, often by habit. The words above come from the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, the prayer of the month of Shaʿban, and they ask forgiveness for something else. They name no particular wrong. They confess a whole life wasted in forgetting God, and a youth spent intoxicated with keeping away from Him.

A request of this kind is where the road to God begins. Of the four stages Chapter Eight set out, the first is polishing (*tajliya*), and repentance opens it. This chapter sets out the first stage in full. Anyone can begin it, by repenting. Repentance is then kept up at a steady pace. The law is kept strictly, starting with how we treat people.

[14] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 164.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *tajliya*: polishing, the first stage of the road · *tawba*: repentance, turning back to God · *istighfar*: asking God's forgiveness · *mujahada*: the struggle against the self · *husn al-khuluq*: good character and conduct towards people

Anyone can begin

Setting out takes two moves. The first is to wake up. We have been living as if asleep, heedless of a God who is near. The second move is to repent, and the mystics call this the first and most important step of the road. Imam Khomeini gives the same order in *Forty Hadith*: when the heart "awakes from its slumber of negligence, this state of awakening is followed by that of repentance"[15].

Repentance (*tawba*) in this sense reaches further than sins. It is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "repenting from our casualness towards the Lord". We repent from taking everything for granted, from wasting our lives, and from not heeding the presence of God. No one is punished for these things. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), sets this repentance beside the familiar kind: "the repentance of the elite is for being occupied with anything other than Allah, and the repentance of the common people is for wrong actions"[16].

Repentance of this kind is open to a sinner as much as to a devout believer, because it covers every sin and every wrong attitude towards God. Among the early mystics were men who had lived as wrongdoers, Bishr al-Hafi and Fudayl ibn ʿIyad among them, until something struck a chord in their souls. They repented wholeheartedly, gave themselves to the religion of God, and set out on the road. Fudayl's turning came through a single verse.

STORY: FUDAYL THE HIGHWAYMAN

Sheikh Bahmanpour tells the story of Fudayl ibn ʿIyad among his accounts of the early mystics. Fudayl was born in Samarqand, lived in Kufa, and died in Mecca in 187 AH, a contemporary of Imam al-Kazim (as) and Imam al-Rida (as). In his early life he was a highwayman. Once the young Fudayl climbed the wall of a house to reach a girl he loved. Someone inside was reciting the Qur'an, and he heard a verse of Surah al-Hadid.

[15] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 249.
[16] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 48.

> ۞أَلَمۡ يَأۡنِ لِلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوٓاْ أَن تَخۡشَعَ قُلُوبُهُمۡ لِذِكۡرِ ٱللَّهِ وَمَا نَزَلَ مِنَ ٱلۡحَقِّ
>
> *Is it not time yet for those who have faith that their hearts should be humbled for Allah's remembrance and toward the truth which has come down [to them],*
>
> Qur'an 57:16
>
> "Yes, it is time, my Lord," Fudayl answered. He turned back, went out into the desert, and began a life of hard austerity in repentance for what he had done. His repentance was sincere (*tawba nasuh*), and he became a great figure of the path, known for his fear of God and his weeping. He narrated many hadith from Imam al-Sadiq (as), and both traditions trust him: al-Kulayni reports his hadith in *al-Kafi*, and al-Bukhari reports them in his *Sahih*.

What holds a sinner back is not the sin but despair. Many believers look at their past and conclude that this path is not for them. They allow that God may forgive them and admit them to jannah. The road to Him is another matter; in their eyes it belongs to people of a higher calibre. God would hardly accept on it someone who has wasted so much. A verse of Surah al-Zumar speaks to exactly this.

۞قُلۡ يَٰعِبَادِيَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَسۡرَفُواْ عَلَىٰٓ أَنفُسِهِمۡ لَا تَقۡنَطُواْ مِن رَّحۡمَةِ ٱللَّهِۚ إِنَّ ٱللَّهَ يَغۡفِرُ ٱلذُّنُوبَ جَمِيعًا

Say [that Allah declares,] 'O My servants who have committed excesses against their own souls, do not despair of the mercy of Allah. Indeed Allah will forgive all sins.

Qur'an 39:53

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads "who have committed excesses against their own souls" broadly. The words can mean real sins, but they also fit those who have wasted much of the capacity in their souls and now despair of moving on the path. The verse tells them not to despair, because God forgives all sins. It is an encouragement for the beginning of the road, so that no believer sets the road aside as meant for others.

Sincere repentance brings more than forgiveness. In *Forty Hadith*, Imam Khomeini cites Imam al-Sadiq (as): when a servant turns to God with sincere repentance, "God loves him and covers him (i.e. his sins) in the world and

the Hereafter"[17]. *Lantern of the Path* says what it does to the heart, which God created pure and clean. "When the pure heart turns grey by being fed on heedlessness and vexation, it is polished by the burnish of repentance and cleaned by the water of regret"[18]. This is the polishing that gives the first stage its name.

Anyone can therefore begin, and the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah gives the words to begin with. Near its end, the one praying comes before God as sinner and penitent at once.

إِلٰهِي أَنَا عَبْدُكَ ٱلضَّعِيفُ ٱلْمُذْنِبُ وَمَمْلُوكُكَ ٱلْمُنِيبُ

My Lord, I am Your powerless sinning slave and Your repentant bondman.[19]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The sentence admits weakness and sin, and in the same breath claims the name of God's repentant servant, in words any believer can say, whatever lies behind them.

Steady, not fast

Once a traveller has begun with repentance, an old habit may still return. When it does, the traveller repents again. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls repentance a continuous process, not a single act. ʿAllama Tabataba'i sets the standard beside it: a repented sin "must not be committed again"[20]. The traveller holds to that standard, and repents again on falling short of it.

Old habits return because the self fights back. The traveller's struggle with the self (*mujahada*) goes on through every stage of the road. At each stage there is a danger that the self "would come back and ... take revenge", and when it strikes hard, it can leave a person reeling for days.

Because the self can strike back, rushing ahead is dangerous. A traveller who pushes forward faster than the self can carry may suddenly fall. A traveller may

[17] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 249.
[18] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 59.
[19] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.
[20] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 89.

also arrive quickly at something and mistake it for the end of the road, which is why the right instruction matters. Sheikh Bahmanpour asks his listeners to be aware of "the dangers of rushing things forward" and to walk the road at the pace the Imams (as) advised. He illustrates the point with a story a friend from Iran had told him that morning.

The friend, the son of a scholar in Tehran, had gone through a time in his youth when his heart was heavy and full of doubts. On someone's advice he began reciting Ziyarat ʿAshura every morning in full, with its hundred curses and hundred greetings. Over a long time it took effect. He felt elated, and people could see a light in his face. Then an elder of the path, a regular guest of the family in Tehran, saw his face and recognised that he was doing some practice. He told the father to make his son stop.

The young man felt so well that he asked why he should stop. The elder answered, "because you need to have basis. You are rushing." He was pushing himself forward too fast, and he might suddenly fall. Progress has to be built on a foundation and come gradually. The lecture compares it with someone who suddenly fasts for three months. Such a person gains great spiritual energy and then feels abandoned by their own soul, unable to carry it further.

Imam al-Sadiq (as) gave the same counsel of pace. He told ʿAbd al-ʿAziz al-Qaratisi that faith has ten degrees "like the steps of a ladder which are climbed one by one. If you find anyone below you by one step, pull him up to you gently and do not burden him with what he cannot bear, or else you will break him"[21].

ʿAllama Tabataba'i draws from this hadith the traveller's rule of moderation. A beginner full of zeal may take on every good practice at once and then tire of it, leaving the work incomplete. In his words, "Too much enthusiasm in the beginning leads to too little interest in the end"[22].

Not rushing is not the same as putting off. Some older believers conclude that the road is closed to them, which the lectures count as despair of God's mercy too. With age the road does become harder, as energy and capacity diminish, yet "it is not impossible", because age limits a person's ability and not the mercy of God. Imam Khomeini presses harder: "do not postpone the

[21] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 89.
[22] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 89.

task of reform to old age"[23], since youth is "the springtime for tawbah"[24]. Both agree that the sooner the road is begun, the easier it is.

Repentance is therefore kept up at a steady pace. It is renewed whenever the traveller falls and taken no faster than the self can bear, and it is not put off to old age, which only makes it harder.

The law, starting with people

Repentance opens the first stage, and keeping the law makes up the rest of it. Polishing (*tajliya*) means keeping what the Prophet ﷺ ordered "in the strictest sense": doing the obligatory and the recommended acts, and avoiding the forbidden and the disliked. Chapter Six set out why this keeping lasts to the end of the road. In Shia mysticism, a traveller who has not polished soul and body by what the shariʿa says cannot move on to the next stage.

Within the law, one demand comes first. After repentance, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "the first and [foremost] and most important condition is to behave yourself with regards to people". A traveller may carry out every kind of repentance and every practice and still not go forward, because relations with people have soured. This first condition is good character and conduct (*husn al-khuluq*).

The reason is a "system of justice". In the lectures, this system underlies every action in this world, and it is "very, very strong". A wrong done to anyone, even to an animal, holds the traveller back from rising through the stations. The system will not let the traveller advance until such wrongs are put right, and this includes wrongs done without knowing it. The inner road therefore cannot go around people.

Good behaviour also stands at the centre of the religion. Sayyid Haydar Amuli, a fourteenth-century teacher of the path, places it "at the very core of the Prophet's message and purpose" and quotes the Prophet's words, "I have been sent to perfect good behaviour"[25].

The Prophet ﷺ and the Imams (as) show what this looks like at the highest station. They stood at the summit of the path, yet everyone loved to sit and

[23] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 127.
[24] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 250.
[25] Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 108.

talk with them, and they were pleasant and friendly with all. However high mystics rise, they have to stay friendly with ordinary people. Imam ʻAli (as), describing the pious in one of his orations, names these among their qualities.

يعفو عمّن ظلمه ويعطي من حرمه ويصل من قطعه

They forgive those who oppress them, give to those who refuse them, and foster those who cut them off.[26]

Nahj al-Balagha

Good conduct of this kind reaches down to the smallest courtesy shown to an ordinary person. One of the early mystics carried a nickname for the rest of his life because of one such courtesy.

STORY: HATIM THE DEAF

Hatim al-Asamm was one of the great mystics of the early centuries, called the Luqman of this ummah. *Al-Asamm* means "the Deaf", though Hatim was not deaf. Sheikh Bahmanpour tells how he came by the name. A woman once came to him with a question. As she asked it, an embarrassing sound escaped her, and she was mortified. Hatim sensed her embarrassment. "What did you say?" he asked. "I didn't hear." She repeated the question more loudly, and again he said that he had not heard. She left certain that he was deaf, and relieved of her embarrassment. From then on he was known as Hatim the Deaf. In the lecture's words, "It is actually praise for his personality, the way he treated just an ordinary lady coming to him."

The first stage, polishing, therefore begins with repentance. Repentance is open to anyone after any sin, and it is kept up at a steady pace. The rest of the stage is the law, kept strictly. Its first demand is that the traveller put things right with people, down to sparing an ordinary person's embarrassment.

Polishing is open to every believer. Where does ʻirfan proper begin?

➤ TRY THIS

Sheikh Bahmanpour suggests beginning the road with a prayer of repentance that, the Mafatih reports, the Prophet ﷺ recommended for Sundays in the month of Dhu'l-Qaʻdah[27]. According to the lectures, the traditionists allow it at

[26] Imam ʻAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.191.

any time, though a Sunday of that month is its best time. On that day, take a ritual bath (*ghusl*) and make wudu. Then pray four rakʿas, two at a time like every recommended prayer, reciting in each Surah al-Fatiha once, Surah al-Tawhid three times, and Surahs al-Falaq and al-Nas once each. Afterwards say *astaghfirullah* one hundred times (the lectures give seventy and name al-Nas alone; the Mafatih's count is followed here), then *la hawla wa la quwwata illa billahil-ʿaliyyil-ʿazim*. Then say the short supplication the Mafatih gives, which calls on God as the Mighty and the All-Forgiving and asks Him to forgive your sins and those of all believing men and women, since none forgives sins but Him. Among the rewards the Mafatih reports are that the repentance is accepted, and that those who pray it will find their rivals pleased with them on the Day of Resurrection[28].

[27] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 356.
[28] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 356.

10

Emptying: the five disciplines

وَلِسَاناً يُرْفَعُ إِلَيْكَ صِدْقُهُ

... with a tongue the truth of which may be submitted to You[29]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

These words come from the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, which many of us recite in the month of Shaʿban, on the threshold of Ramadan. The line asks God for a tongue whose truthfulness rises to Him. A month later, in Ramadan, we keep most of the disciplines of this chapter without naming them. We go hungry by day and wake before dawn. We speak fewer idle words, and we give more of our time to the Qur'an and the remembrance of God.

'Irfan keeps a measure of these disciplines all year. The road has four stages. The first two are the traveller's own work, polishing the self and then emptying the heart (*takhliya*), and the last two are God's gifts to the emptied heart. The lectures call the five disciplines instruments of the whole journey. This book reads them as the tools of its second stage, emptying, because their target is the heart. This chapter sets out emptying, its five disciplines, and how much of each to take.

[29]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §83.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *takhliya*: emptying the heart of every occupation other than God · *samt*: silence · *juʿ*: hunger, kept short of weakness · *salat al-layl*: the night prayer · *khalwa* or *ʿuzla*: seclusion · *dhikr*: the remembrance of God

Where ʿirfan begins

Polishing (*tajliya*), the road's first stage, is what any believer can begin. It starts with repentance and goes on in keeping the law strictly, the recommended acts as well as the obligatory, and it stays with the traveller to the end of the road. ʿIrfan proper begins at the next stage. The lectures read out a line of the philosopher Ibn Sina on where ʿirfan begins. The beginning he names is emptying the heart, which the traveller takes up once polishing is in place.

Emptying clears the heart of whatever occupies it other than God. Keeping the practices of the law is easy by comparison. Abstaining from wine, or from the company of certain people, is a decision a person can make and keep; abstaining from thinking ill of others is far harder, and keeping the heart on God alone is harder still. Anyone who has tried to keep every other thought out of salah knows this.

Keeping the heart on God alone does not mean loving nothing else. The test is what occupies the heart, not what it loves. We may love many things that do not compete with the love of God, and some of them are wholly in line with it. These loves stay. What emptying clears is whatever diverts the heart and stops us giving ourselves wholly to God.

Ibn Sina names four steps in emptying. The first is separating the heart from what diverts it, and the second is dusting off the traces. Leaving, the third, is letting go with some reluctance. Rejecting, the fourth, is no longer wanting the thing at all. The last thing rejected is the self, since we worry about ourselves and think we must keep some independence from God. The lectures compare leaning the self on God to a non-swimmer thrown into the sea. At first it feels like drowning. With practice, staying afloat becomes a pleasure. The soul learns that leaning on God is where it has to be.

Mystics of every faith name the same five disciplines as instruments of the journey. They are silence, hunger, the night vigil, seclusion, and the constant remembrance of God. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), says true rest comes only on meeting God, though four of these give rest too.

Wakefulness, it says, "illuminates your heart, purifies your nature and cleanses your spirit"[30]. The lectures tie remembrance to emptying, and this book places all five there. Each is an act the law recommends, so keeping it is still polishing. What makes the five the tools of emptying is their target, the heart.

Emptying is therefore the second stage of the road, and the five disciplines are its tools. We can read three of them as shutting the doors through which the world fills the heart, and two as working on the heart itself. The next two sections take them in that order.

Silence, hunger, and the night

The first door is the tongue, and silence (*samt*) shuts it. The silence meant here is not a lifelong vow, since the tongue was given to us to speak. It means speaking only of what concerns us and what benefits us or others, and leaving aside idle talk and other people's business. In *Kernel of the Kernels*, ʿAllama Tabataba'i cites a saying of Imam al-Rida (as) that ties this silence to wisdom.

> *Silence is a door from among the doors of wisdom, and it is indeed the guide to all goodness.*[31]
>
> Hadith

The second door is the stomach, and hunger (*juʿ*) shuts it. The hunger meant here is not going without food for days. It means never eating to the point of heaviness. A full stomach draws the soul's whole attention to itself, and then, in the Sheikh's words, "the mind goes dizzy and you cannot remember God". In the story told in Chapter Seven, the first counsels Imam al-Sadiq (as) gave ʿUnwan al-Basri were rules of this kind. He was to eat only when hungry, and to eat only what is lawful.

STORY: THE GUEST OF THE MOSQUE

ʿAllama Tabataba'i's teacher, Mirza ʿAli Aqa Qadi, used to tell a story about hunger, which *Kernel of the Kernels* records. In the days of the earlier prophets, three friends arrived as strangers in a town. At nightfall they went their separate ways to find food, and agreed to meet at a set place the next day. One of them

[30] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 56.

[31] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 76.

> received an invitation, and another became someone’s guest. The third had nowhere to go, and said to himself that he would go to the mosque and be God’s guest. He stayed there until morning and remained hungry. When the three met and told one another what had happened, God revealed to the prophet of that time a message for the third man: “We accepted the hospitality of this dear guest. We were his host and we desired to offer him the best of foods. But on searching Our stores We did not find any better food for him than hunger”[32].

Silence and hunger guard the heart against the chain of idle thoughts, which is among the hardest things to stop. We imagine something, then imagine wanting it, then imagine ways of getting it, and the chain drags us towards sin and away from worship. Silence and hunger give the strength to block it; they also open the way to watchfulness of God (*muraqaba*), the sense that He is present and sees us. In the hadith of the Prophet’s ascension, which Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi records, God says that “the result of silence is wisdom; the result of wisdom is enlightenment; the result of enlightenment is certainty”[33].

The third door is sleep, and the night prayer (*salat al-layl*) shuts it. The Qur’an says little about silence or hunger, but it speaks often of the night vigil. Surah al-Muzzammil opens by telling the Prophet ﷺ to rise at night.

قُمِ ٱلَّيۡلَ إِلَّا قَلِيلٗا ﴿٢﴾ نِّصۡفَهُۥٓ أَوِ ٱنقُصۡ مِنۡهُ قَلِيلًا ﴿٣﴾ أَوۡ زِدۡ عَلَيۡهِ وَرَتِّلِ ٱلۡقُرۡءَانَ تَرۡتِيلًا ﴿٤﴾

Stand vigil through the night, except for a little [of it], a half, or reduce a little from that or add to it, and recite the Quran in a measured tone.

Qur’an 73:2-4

The command is for half the night, a little less, or a little more. Two verses later the surah gives the reason.

[32] ʿAllama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 76–77.

[33] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 16.

إِنَّ نَاشِئَةَ ٱلَّيۡلِ هِيَ أَشَدُّ وَطۡئٗا وَأَقۡوَمُ قِيلٗا ﴿٦﴾ إِنَّ لَكَ فِي ٱلنَّهَارِ سَبۡحٗا طَوِيلٗا ﴿٧﴾

Indeed the watch of the night is firmer in tread and more upright in respect to speech, for indeed during the day you have drawn-out engagements.

Qur'an 73:6-7

The day is full of drawn-out engagements, so the pure remembrance of God becomes possible at night. After sleep the body is rested and the memory is fresh. The attention is gathered rather than scattered, and the stomach is empty. Rising in the middle of the night also shows how seriously a person holds their faith, and a command the Prophet ﷺ was given is an example for the rest of us. Surah al-Dhariyat counts the same habit among the marks of the righteous.

كَانُواْ قَلِيلٗا مِّنَ ٱلَّيۡلِ مَا يَهۡجَعُونَ ﴿١٧﴾ وَبِٱلۡأَسۡحَارِ هُمۡ يَسۡتَغۡفِرُونَ ﴿١٨﴾

They used to sleep a little during the night, and at dawns they would plead for forgiveness,

Qur'an 51:17-18

The righteous of this verse chose to sleep little. Read together, the three disciplines work in the same way. A held tongue, a light stomach, and an hour awake before the day's engagements begin each leave more of the heart's attention free for God.

The tongue, the stomach, and sleep are therefore the doors these three disciplines shut. What the world has already left inside the heart is the work of the other two.

Seclusion and remembrance

Of the two disciplines that work on the heart itself, seclusion (*khalwa* or *'uzla*) comes first. The Sufi orders differ over it. Some ask beginners for forty days of retreat, whereas others advise against it. In Shia 'irfan, as Sheikh Bahmanpour describes it, seclusion is taken from the Qur'an, and it is "seclusion of the heart rather than seclusion of the body". Some seclusion of the body may help, as in the retreat in the mosque (*i'tikaf*) that the Prophet ﷺ kept in the last ten

days of Ramadan. We can read seclusion of the heart as Ibn Sina's first step, separating the heart from what diverts it.

Surah al-Muzzammil, which asks for the night prayer, also asks for this seclusion.

وَٱذۡكُرِ ٱسۡمَ رَبِّكَ وَتَبَتَّلۡ إِلَيۡهِ تَبۡتِيلًا ﴿٨﴾

So celebrate the Name of your Lord and dedicate yourself to Him with total dedication.

Qur'an 73:8

The verse asks for total dedication, yet the Prophet did not cut himself off from people after it came down. His whole life was lived among them, with his family, his companions, and his battles. What he turned wholly to God was his heart. A heart turned this way, in the lectures' image, can live in a big industrial city "just as if you're living in a cave". A person in a real cave whose thoughts are always elsewhere has no seclusion at all.

ع **WORD STUDY: TABATTUL**

The verse joins a verb to its own noun, *tabattal ilayhi tabtila*, which the translation used here renders "dedicate yourself to Him with total dedication". The lectures gloss *tabattul* as cutting oneself off from everyone and everything towards the Lord. The verse names only the One the heart turns to, and not what it leaves. Its first hearer went on living among people, so the cutting off is in the heart. The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah makes the same request in a line Chapter Three quoted: "My Lord, grant me complete severance of my relations with everything else"[34]. The lectures call this one of the paradoxes of ʿirfan, in which the traveller is cut off and not cut off, social and not social.

The night prayer of the last section is the traveller's daily seclusion. In *salat al-layl* a believer is completely alone with God, every night, for half an hour or more. The lectures call it a continuous seclusion.

Separating leaves traces behind, as roots can remain when a diseased growth is cut out. The remembrance of God (*dhikr*) dusts off those traces, and this is Ibn Sina's second step. For the mystic its effect is real and present, not only

[34] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

a reward stored up for the next world. Ten repetitions of *subhan Allah*, *al-hamdu lillah*, *la ilaha illa Allah*, and *Allahu akbar* each morning and evening dust off what remains of the heart's desire for this world. The soul takes the shape of whatever it is given, as water takes the shape of its vessel. The Qur'an asks that this remembrance be frequent.

يَٰٓأَيُّهَا ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُواْ ٱذۡكُرُواْ ٱللَّهَ ذِكۡرٗا كَثِيرٗا ﴿٤١﴾

O you who have faith! Remember Allah with frequent remembrance,

Qur'an 33:41

The Mafatih records, according to validly reported traditions, that this "frequent remembrance" is the Tasbih of al-Zahra'. This is the glorification named after Lady Fatima (as) and recited after each obligatory prayer, and "whoever abides by it will have remembered Almighty Allah frequently"[35]. The lectures call it the minimum, provided it is said with attention and not out of habit. Beyond that minimum, remembrance has no limit. In the Sufi orders a shaykh assigns the words of remembrance, whereas in the Shia tradition they are already in the hadith and a teacher only chooses which suit the traveller.

The effect is present because remembrance is answered. God says, "Remember Me and I will remember you" (Q 2:152). He forgets nothing, so the lectures read His remembering as His favour coming down on the one who remembers Him. That favour is present everywhere and at every moment, and constant remembrance is how a person comes to receive it.

Seclusion therefore separates the heart from what distracts it, and remembrance dusts off what remains. With silence, hunger, and the night prayer, these are the five tools of emptying.

A medicine, measured to the patient

None of the five is kept to the full. Lifelong silence is asked of no one, since the Prophet ﷺ and Imam ʿAli (as) spoke a great deal and their words fill the books of hadith. Fasting is commanded, but fasting two days on end without breaking the fast is forbidden. Seclusion and constant remembrance have to fit lives with families and duties. Even the night prayer was eased within the

[35] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 802.

Qur'an. The last verse of Surah al-Muzzammil recalls that the Prophet ﷺ stood for two thirds of the night, a half, or a third. Then it eases the command.

عَلِمَ أَن لَّن تُحۡصُوهُ فَتَابَ عَلَيۡكُمۡۖ فَٱقۡرَءُواْ مَا تَيَسَّرَ مِنَ ٱلۡقُرۡءَانِۚ

He knows that you cannot calculate it [exactly], and so He was lenient toward you. So recite as much of the Quran as is feasible.

Qur'an 73:20

The verse grants leniency because God knows what His servants can keep up. Of each discipline, Sheikh Bahmanpour asks the same question, "where is the balance". The answer is set by what the person can carry, and not by straining to imitate the Prophet ﷺ, whose practice called for a personality like his.

To begin the night prayer, half an hour is enough. If eagerness comes, it can grow gradually to an hour or an hour and a half, and probably no more. Going past the limit has a bad effect later, until "we just stop and we just quit". The teachers of this road asked a student to keep one practice for at least a year, such as reciting Surah al-Muzzammil each night, which takes about three minutes. The same holds for the body. Fifteen minutes in prostration tires our limbs because we are not yet used to it.

The written guides of the road give the same measures. ʿAllama Tabataba'i's programme in *Kernel of the Kernels* keeps hunger "to the extent that it does not lead to weakness"[36]. It asks for wakefulness at dawn "to the extent permitted by the wayfarer's constitution"[37]. In the same programme, as *Light Within Me* gives it, the words of remembrance are weighed one person at a time, since "The liturgies are just like a medicine which may suit some and may not suit others"[38]. *Lantern of the Path* asks for worship that is "most free of harm and the most consistent, be it ever so small"[39].

Seclusion is measured the same way. For the spoken remembrances, *Kernel of the Kernels* asks for a room for one person, away from crowds, and such a seclusion is "considered essential by the masters"[40]. *Lantern of the Path* says

[36] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 76.
[37] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 78.
[38] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 102.
[39] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari'a), p. 55.
[40] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 77.

that every prophet and regent "has chosen retreat in his lifetime, either at his beginning or at his end"[41]. Long austerities aimed at unusual powers are another matter. ʿAllama Tabataba'i, whom the lectures quote, said forty days of them can stir such powers, and that "it is possible, but it's not desirable". The seclusion the lectures recommend is the hour alone with God each night.

Emptying therefore clears the heart of every "occupation other than Allah". Silence, hunger, and the night prayer shut the doors of the tongue, the stomach, and sleep. Seclusion separates the heart from what distracts it, and remembrance dusts off what remains. Each of the five is taken in a dose measured to the person, small at first and kept up for a year or more.

Emptying ends at the self, the last thing left behind. What follows is no longer the traveller's work. What does God give the emptied heart?

> **TRY THIS**
>
> Imam ʿAli (as) calls remembrance "the burnish for your hearts", by which "you can hear after your earlier deafness, see after your earlier night-blindness"[42]. This week, after each obligatory prayer, recite the Tasbih of al-Zahra' slowly and with attention. In the method the Mafatih calls "the most famous", it is *Allahu akbar* thirty-four times, *al-hamdu lillah* thirty-three times, and *subhan Allah* thirty-three times[43]. Say each phrase to God, not as a routine to get through. It is the minimum of the frequent remembrance the Qur'an asks for.

[41] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 50.
[42] Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.219.1, p. 522.
[43] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, pp. 802–803.

11

Adorning: love, the engine

وَإِنْ أَدْخَلْتَنِي ٱلنَّارَ أَعْلَمْتُ أَهْلَهَا أَنِّي أُحِبُّكَ

If You haul me into the hell, I will tell its inmates that I love You.[44]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

These words come from the Munajat Sha'baniyyah. The Mafatih reports that Imam 'Ali (as) and the other Imams said this prayer in the month of Sha'ban[45], and many of us recite it in that month too. The lines just before it ask for pardon, promising to cling to God's forgiveness whatever sins are held against the one praying. Then comes a sentence no trader would say. A trader weighs what he gives against what he hopes to get, whereas this reciter pictures the fire itself and still declares love.

Another line of the same Munajat, the one at the head of Part One, says where such love comes from. There the one praying admits to having had no strength to move away from disobedience except when God awakened them to His love.

[44]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 164; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §59.

[45]Shaykh 'Abbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.

That awakening has its place on the road to God, which has four stages. The first two, polishing the self and emptying the heart, are the traveller's work. With the third, adorning, the work passes from the traveller to God. This chapter sets out what God gives the emptied heart in that stage. Love is among His gifts, and it carries the traveller until even love is left at the door.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *tahliya*: adorning; God's gifts to the emptied heart · *mahabba*: love, above all the love of God · *khawf*: fear of God · *zuhd*: renunciation of the world · *'ibadat al-ahrar*: the worship of the free, who worship God for His own sake

What God gives the emptied heart

Adorning (*tahliya*) is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "Allah's act on the soul", not the traveller's. Once the self is polished and the heart emptied, the soul begins to take its adornment from the spiritual world, and God feeds it with what others cannot take in. The mystics name what comes as visions, inspirations (*ilham*), and a deeper understanding of the Qur'an. God gives these through the angels, the lecture adds, and the angels bring them to everyone.

What the traveller's own work makes is a soul able to catch them. Sayyid Haydar Amuli describes the change that comes when the self gives its energy to true spiritual exercises. It loses its vices (vanity, arrogance, and envy among them) and takes on "gnosis, wisdom, forbearance, humility, generosity, chastity and courage"[46]. A soul purified in this way sees and hears what others cannot, "not because ... they are chosen ones but because they have furbished their souls". The soul that was blind begins to see. Surah al-An'am describes such a person.

أَوَمَن كَانَ مَيْتًا فَأَحْيَيْنَٰهُ وَجَعَلْنَا لَهُۥ نُورًا يَمْشِى بِهِۦ فِى ٱلنَّاسِ

Is he who was lifeless, then We gave him life and provided him with a light by which he walks among the people

Qur'an 6:122

[46]Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 109.

The verse joins the new life to a light, and the one given it walks with that light among the people. Many verses of the Qur’an speak of this new life, which true faith brings.

Knowledge received in this way is a reward the Qur’an promises to those who do good. Surah Yusuf says so of the Prophet Yusuf (as), before he was given his mission.

وَلَمَّا بَلَغَ أَشُدَّهُۥٓ ءَاتَيۡنَٰهُ حُكۡمٗا وَعِلۡمٗاۚ وَكَذَٰلِكَ نَجۡزِي ٱلۡمُحۡسِنِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

When he came of age, We gave him judgement and [sacred] knowledge, and thus do We reward the virtuous.

Qur’an 12:22

The verse’s last words state a general rule. The virtuous (*muhsinin*) are those with depth of faith (*ihsan*), and whoever has it is rewarded with knowledge that does not come from reading books or analysing concepts. God puts it in the heart. Giving to the deprived and relying on God are among the marks of *ihsan*.

Sheikh Bahmanpour saw such knowledge in a preacher in Tehran whose gatherings many people attended every week, and he went to them himself. The preacher had almost no formal learning and had not studied the hadith. He would state a teaching and then ask his listeners for the hadith or the verse behind it, sure that one existed. He knew the ideas of the hadith without having read them. Study still matters, and the mystics, Imam Khomeini among them, all studied formally. Study alone repeats a teacher’s concepts, whereas study matched with the knowledge God gives the heart resonates with it, and the two reinforce each other.

At first the gifts come briefly and are gone. Ibn Sina’s account of the first lights of the path fits this stage. As Murtada Mutahhari quotes him, flashes of the light of the Real (God) are at first “momentary like flashes of lightning appearing and instantly vanishing”. With practice they come more often, until “the flashes become a prolonged blaze” and the traveller reaches “an enduring gnostic state which permanently accompanies him”[47]. The order has a reason.

[47] Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 48.

A light seen without its cloud would burn the eyes. In God's mercy it shines at first from behind the clouds, while the heart widens to receive more.

Later the light stays and becomes the traveller's delight. If it leaves him, Ibn Sina says, "he becomes sad and bewildered"[48]. Uways al-Qarani shows what this stage looks like. He was a companion of Imam ʿAli (as), and the mystics trace their chains through him[49]. It is reported that he waited all day for the night. When it came, he said that this night was for bowing (*ruku'*), and he stayed bowed until morning. The next night he spent in prostration (*sajda*).

Someone asked whether the long nights tired him. He answered that the night was not long to him but short. He is also reported to have wished that his whole life were a single night, passed in one prostration to God. The light had come to stay, and the body follows the soul. The body tires in prayer when the soul is after other pleasures, and it does not tire when the soul wants God.

Even gifts that stay are not arrival, and the lectures call them "not a great deal", since a long way remains. Wonders prove nothing either. They come at the stage of spiritual disclosure, and a great distance separates that stage from the end of the road[50].

Love, the gift the Imams asked for

Among the gifts of this stage is love, and it too cannot be made by us. No one reads a book and falls in love with God. After the soul has been purified, love is placed in the heart by God. Sheikh Bahmanpour explains how it comes. God "shows the face of Himself" to people, and what they see is so lovely that they can think of nothing else. The gifts of adorning reach everyone, though only the purified catch them. This face is different. The lecture says it is shown only to those who deserve it.

The lecture offers a simple comparison. Two people fall in love because each has seen something in the other that draws them. In the same way, when God shows the heart something beautiful of Himself, the heart falls in love with Him. Once given, this love cannot be removed by anyone. How far it absorbs a person depends on their capacity, and some can speak of nothing

[48] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 48.
[49] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 5.
[50] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 81.

else. The capacity of the prophets is the highest, and the Prophet ﷺ, though shown the best face of Allah, still lived like other people. The lectures do not cite it, but Surah al-Ma'ida speaks of such a people.

فَسَوْفَ يَأْتِي ٱللَّهُ بِقَوْمٍ يُحِبُّهُمْ وَيُحِبُّونَهُۥٓ

Allah will soon bring a people whom He loves and who love Him

Qur'an 5:54

> ع **WORD STUDY: MAHABBA**
> *Mahabba* is the Arabic word for love, and the love of God is one of the two things ʻirfan seeks, beside knowing Him. The verse above uses verbs from the same root for both sides of the love: God "loves" them (*yuhibbuhum*), and they "love Him" (*yuhibbunahu*). The Munajat Shaʻbaniyyah uses the noun itself when it speaks of God awakening the one who prays "to Your love" (*li-mahabbatika*)[51]. The Lovers of the Whispered Prayer are the *muhibbin*, "those who love", from the same root again. ʻAllama Tabataba'i gives the word a plain sense, "Love means attraction, or in other words to be drawn by some person or some truth"[52]. On that sense, to love God is to be drawn to Him. Read with the Munajat's line, the verse suggests to this book that the drawing begins on His side.

Because love is given, the Imams (as) always asked for it. In effect they asked to be shown the face of God that would absorb them in His love. Imam ʻAli (as) taught Duʻa Kumayl to Kumayl ibn Ziyad, and many of us recite it on Thursday evenings, as the Mafatih recommends[53]. It treats separation from God as harder to bear than His punishment.

[51] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 164; *Munajat Shaʻbaniyyah* (duas.org), §74.

[52] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 95.

[53] Shaykh ʻAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.

فَهَبْنِي يَا إِلَهِي وَسَيِّدِي وَمَوْلاي وَرَبِّي صَبَرْتُ عَلَى عَذَابِكَ، فَكَيْفَ أَصْبِرُ عَلَى فِرَاقِكَ

Then suppose, My God, my Master, my Protector and my Lord that I am able to endure Your chastisement, How can I endure separation from You?[54]

Du'a Kumayl

Punishment, the one praying supposes, might be endured, whereas separation from God could not. The du'a goes on in the same voice as the Munajat line at the head of this chapter. If left with speech among the fire's inhabitants, the one praying will still lament and cry out to God, as the hopeful and the bereft do[55]. Imam Zayn al-'Abidin (as) opens the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers with a question of the same kind.

My God, who can have tasted the sweetness of Thy love, then wanted another in place of Thee?[56]

Whispered Prayer of the Lovers

A heart that has tasted that sweetness wants nothing in God's place, and this love carries the traveller. The early mystics walked with fear (*khawf*), renunciation (*zuhd*), and love, and each had all three. In the lectures' telling, love became in the end the victorious side of mysticism in Islam. They also call love the heart of mysticism. *Lantern of the Path* puts fear first and hope next, with love following when "the breeze of love stirs"[57]. Fear keeps its place too, and the *Kernel of the Kernels* places perfection in "possessing perfect expansion while possessing perfect fear", which is "exclusive to the Immaculate Imams"[58].

Worship that comes from love is a different kind of worship, the worship of the free (*'ibadat al-ahrar*). Imam 'Ali (as) names three kinds in Nahj al-Balagha.

[54] *Du'a Kumayl* (duas.org), §123–124.
[55] *Du'a Kumayl* (duas.org), §128–131.
[56] Imam Zayn al-'Abidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 656.
[57] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari'a), p. 58.
[58] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 70.

> *Some worship God out of desire for His reward—that is the worship of merchants. Others worship God from fear of His punishment—that is the worship of slaves. A third group worship God to give thanks for His favors—that is the worship of the free![59]*
>
> Nahj al-Balagha

The merchant worships for a price and the slave from fear, whereas the free, in Imam ʻAli's saying, worship to give thanks. A report from Imam al-Sadiq (as), which ʻAllama Tabataba'i records, gives the free a second reason. They worship Allah because they love Him, and their worship "is that of freemen"[60]. The lectures give a third reason, that the free worship God "because He deserves to be worshipped". A prayer of Imam ʻAli (as) that Tabataba'i quotes gives the same reason, since in it he worships God because he has found Him fit for worship[61].

One early mystic of Basra is remembered for this kind of worship. Rabiʻa al-ʻAdawiyya, "one of the wonders of her time"[62], began in the austere, fearful way of the ascetics of her city and moved to the way of love. She taught that even repentance is a gift from God, since no one could repent unless God had first accepted them. The lectures note that much told of her is legend. Her sayings, poems, and prayers are not.

She held that fear and hope, good as they are, could become veils between the servant and God. The story is told that a group of Sufis once saw her hurrying along with water in one hand and a burning torch in the other. They asked her what she was doing. She wanted, she said, to throw fire into paradise and pour water onto hell. Then these two veils would disappear, and it would be clear who worships God out of love and not from fear of hell or hope of paradise. The lectures set her beside the worship of the free that Imam ʻAli (as) describes.

In *Lantern of the Path*, Imam ʻAli (as) is reported to describe this love as a fire.

[59] Imam ʻAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.222.
[60] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 94.
[61] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 95.
[62] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 24.

> *Love of Allah is a fire which does not pass by anything without burning it up; the light of Allah does not come over something without illuminating it.*[63]
>
> Lantern of the Path

The same page says what the fire burns. Once love of Allah takes possession of the servant's innermost being, "it empties him of every preoccupation except remembrance of Allah"[64]. In the stage before, the traveller cleared his heart by his own effort. Love, given by God, carries that clearing on.

Even love is left at the door

Love carries the traveller a long way, but it remains a means. ʿAllama Tabataba'i describes what happens a few stages on: "In the beginning the spiritual traveler goes forward with the help of love, but after traversing a few stages he realizes that love is different from the beloved." The traveller then tries to give up the love that was his means of progress so far, since it "might prove a hindrance in his further advancement". From then on, "he concentrates all his attention on the Beloved Whom he worships as his Beloved only"[65].

Love is the traveller's own state, whereas the Beloved is God. A traveller who keeps looking at his own love is still looking at something of his own, and the love that carried him this far begins to stand between him and the One he loves. The love itself does not leave the heart, since no one can remove it. What the traveller leaves, as this book reads Tabataba'i, is his attention to his own love.

Murtada Mutahhari makes a related point about God's gifts with a story from Saʿdi's *Bustan*. Sultan Mahmud's treasure chest breaks open in a narrow pass. His riders fall on the pearls and corals, while his friend Iyaz rides on after the king. Asked what booty he has brought, Iyaz says he preferred the king's service to treasure. Saʿdi draws the lesson: "If you look to your friend for his favors, / You are tied to yourself not to your friend".

[63] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 88.

[64] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 88.

[65] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 95; see also ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 72–73.

Mutahhari's point is that the ʿarif does not seek God for the sake of His gifts. If he did, the gifts would be what he wanted and God only the means to them. The real object of his desire would then be his own self, since the gifts serve its pleasure[66]. A traveller who has stopped seeking the gifts in God's place is ready to take the same step with his own love.

> ✦ **REFLECTION**
>
> Imam Khomeini speaks to mystics, philosophers, ascetics, jurists, and believers alike. He tells them not to make much of their love for God or to think too well of themselves, and he puts to them a question that any traveller can ask: "Ask your heart whether it is in search of God or whether it is in love with itself"[67]. Think of one act of worship you look forward to. What are you asking of God in it?

Rabiʿa, who carried the torch, comes close to this in a prayer that Sheikh Bahmanpour reads. She asks God to give whatever He has destined for her in this world to His enemies, and whatever He has destined for her in the next to His friends, "since you are more than enough for me". The lecture adds that she wants nothing from Him.

God therefore adorns the emptied heart. He gives it knowledge, a deeper understanding of the Qur'an, and a light to walk by, in flashes at first and later to stay. Among His gifts is love, which the Imams asked for in their prayers. Love carries the traveller and makes worship the worship of the free. At the door even love is left behind, so that only the Beloved remains.

With even love left behind, what remains of the traveller before God?

> ➤ **TRY THIS**
>
> Sheikh Bahmanpour reads from the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers in his first lecture. It is the ninth of the fifteen whispered prayers of Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as) printed with al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya. This week, read it once, slowly[68]. It opens with the question quoted in this chapter. As you read, notice how much of what it asks for is God's to give, such as a place among those "purified through Thy affection and Thy love", and "whose breast Thou hast freed for Thy

[66] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 43–45.
[67] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 89.
[68] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), pp. 656–657.

> love". Near its end the Imam asks directly for love: "I ask from Thee love for Thee"[69].

[69]Imam Zayn al-'Abidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 657.

12

Passing away: losing the self, finding God

Twice in every unit of the prayer (*rak'a*), we go down into prostration (*sujud*). Every other act of the prayer is performed once. With our foreheads on the ground, we glorify our Lord, the Most High, and praise Him. Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi calls this posture "the most supreme state and spiritual position for a human being, i.e., the position of annihilation in Allah", and recalls the tradition that a person in prostration "is nearer to Allah than in any other state"[70].

The annihilation he names is what the mystics call passing away (*fana'*), and in every prostration the body takes its posture for a moment. The traveller reaches the state itself only at the end of a long road. In the third stage, God adorned the emptied heart with His gifts, and love carried the traveller until even love was left at the door. What remains before God is the traveller himself, and the fourth and last stage is about him. This chapter sets out what passing away is: what is lost in losing the self, what is found in finding God, and how the traveller comes back.

[70] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 88.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *fana'*: passing away, the loss of the sense of self before God's glory · *baqa'*: remaining, the life in God that follows · *sukr* / *sahw*: intoxication / sobriety · *shath*: an ecstatic saying · *farq ba'd al-jam'*: separation after unification

What is lost is the false self

Passing away begins at the height of adorning. At the end of that stage God shows the traveller a small measure of His glory. No one can watch that glory and perceive himself at the same time. The glory does not wait for the traveller to clear a space for it. It comes, and everything else goes from his sight, even his sense of himself. Something like it happens to a person seized by great fear or great joy. He can cut his hand and not feel it, because what is in front of him has taken all his attention.

Passing away is therefore a change in what the traveller sees, and not in what exists. Sheikh Bahmanpour defines it as "the annihilation of self perception of the mystics in perceiving the unveiling [of] the reality of God". The world goes on as before. What changes is the traveller's knowing, and so the lectures call passing away "an epistemological issue", a matter of perception and not of existence. 'Allama Tabataba'i says the same of the world around the traveller: "this does not mean that everything in the material world loses its existence. Actually, the devotee sees unity in plurality"[71].

The traveller's soul remains too. What he loses is the sense of self, while "the soul is there, everything is there". Passing away is not nirvana, which the lectures describe as the Buddhist goal of ending individuality. In Islamic mysticism, "it is the individual who is going to be there forever getting more expanded, more capable". If the individual dissolved, no one would be left to taste what God shows, since only an individual can experience anything. The Qur'an keeps the individual even in paradise, where "Their Lord will give them to drink a pure drink" (Q 76:21).

Nor does the traveller become God. Passing away is never a merging of the divine and the human. The lectures call such a merging impossible, and the claim to it shirk, or unbelief (*kufr*). Whoever claims to have dissolved in God, or to have God dwelling in him, has not understood what happened to him.

[71] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 63.

Before God’s glory the traveller stops perceiving himself, but he never stops being a creature.

What goes, then, is the false picture of a self that stands on its own. This self is the last thing emptying leaves behind, and passing away is where it falls. We lost our original self to worldly desires. Passing away breaks the walls of illusion built around us and returns us to the self God created. In Sheikh Bahmanpour’s words, it is a move “out of the imaginary you to the real you”.

ع WORD STUDY: FANA’ AND BAQA’

The two words for this stage come from one pair of verses in Surah al-Rahman.

كُلُّ مَنْ عَلَيْهَا فَانٍ ﴿٢٦﴾ وَيَبْقَىٰ وَجْهُ رَبِّكَ ذُو الْجَلَالِ وَالْإِكْرَامِ ﴿٢٧﴾

Everyone on it is ephemeral, yet lasting is the majestic and munificent Face of your Lord.

Qur’an 55:26-27

“Ephemeral” translates *fanin*, from the root of *fana’*, passing away; “lasting” translates *yabqa*, from the root of *baqa’*, remaining. ‘Allama Tabataba’i’s lectures read the Face of a thing as “that which manifests it”, and the Face of God as His Names, through which every creature faces Him. Everyone on earth is ephemeral, as the verse says, and what lasts is the Face. The traveller who passes away from himself reaches “total annihilation (fana’ kulli) and, thereafter, the station of life in God (baqa’), whereat eternal life becomes established for him”[72].

What is lost in passing away is therefore the false picture of a self that stands apart from God. The soul and the world around it remain, and God remains God.

Three degrees: in action, in attributes, in essence

Passing away does not come all at once. It comes in degrees, and their order follows the order of the veils. Sayyid Haydar Amuli quotes a gnostic: “The essence is veiled by the attributes and the attributes by the action”[73]. The line names three layers, so the unveiling has three degrees. It runs from the

[72] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 14–15.

[73] Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 115.

outermost layer inwards, in action first, then in attributes, and last in essence. ('Allama Tabataba'i counts four, adding a unity of the Names before the last[74].) Let's take the three in turn. Each makes words we already say into something the traveller sees.

The first degree is passing away in action. We think it is our eyes that see, whereas at this degree the traveller realises that "it is really not you who is seeing". When a hand moves, the power in it is God's, flowing into the hand. The intention is ours, though the lectures call its origin one of the most complicated issues. This is the lived truth of a phrase many of us repeat after the prayers, that there is no movement and no power except through God (*la hawla wa la quwwata illa billah*). The traveller comes to the place a verse of Surah al-Kahf describes.

هُنَالِكَ ٱلْوَلَٰيَةُ لِلَّهِ ٱلْحَقِّ ۚ

There, all authority belongs to Allah, the Real.

Qur'an 18:44

That there is no authority but God's is something any believer can work out. A person can think about it for weeks and conclude that God created him and provides for him. The traveller at this degree tastes it. The difference is that between a recipe and the dish. Reading the recipe, we can imagine how the dish will taste, whereas only the cooked dish gives the taste.

The second degree is passing away in attributes. Wherever the traveller looks, even at the material world, he sees the attributes of God at work. Life, knowledge, and power are in everything around him, and all of them are His. This is the lived truth of words we say often, there is no god but God (*la ilaha illa Allah*), because *Allah* is the name that gathers all His attributes. The Throne Verse opens on the attribute of life.

[74] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 107–108.

ٱللَّهُ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ ٱلۡحَيُّ ٱلۡقَيُّومُۚ

Allah—there is no god except Him—is the Living One, the All-sustainer.

Qur’an 2:255

In this verse life belongs to God, and whatever lives does so through Him. The same is true of movement, knowledge, power, and energy, wherever they appear. At this degree the traveller sees them as His wherever he looks.

The third degree is passing away in essence. Here the traveller no longer sees even the attributes. In the lectures’ words, there is “just His glory, which is overshadowing everything”. What is left to him is one word, *Huwa*, “He”. The Qur’an uses this pronoun for God, and it points to Him without naming anything beside Him. In Surah al-Ikhlas it is the word after “Say”.

قُلۡ هُوَ ٱللَّهُ أَحَدٌ ﴿١﴾

Say, ’He is Allah, the One.

Qur’an 112:1

Like the words of the first two degrees, *Huwa* is already on a believer’s tongue. Sheikh Bahmanpour reports a hadith in which Imam ‘Ali (as) is given a whole prayer built on it. Before the battle of Badr, he dreamt of Khidr, whom Musa followed in Surah al-Kahf[75]. He asked Khidr to teach him a prayer he could repeat. Khidr taught him a short prayer that calls on God as *Huwa*, He, besides whom there is none. The histories report that on the day of Badr Imam ‘Ali (as) was seen attacking from every side as he recited Surah al-Ikhlas and the words of this prayer.

The third degree closes the climb, and the prayer this book opened with asks for something close to it. In the Munajat Sha‘baniyyah we ask God to light up the eyes of our hearts until they pierce the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. The sentence, which the Imams (as) placed on our tongues, does not stop at the veils.

[75] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 508.

وَتَصِيرَ أَرْوَاحُنَا مُعَلَّقَةً بِعِزِّ قُدْسِكَ

and let our souls get suspended by the glory of Your sanctity.[76]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

Past the veils, the prayer asks that our souls be held by the glory of God's holiness. Each degree on the way there turns words the believer already says into what the traveller sees: in action, no power except through God; in attributes, no god but God; and in essence, He.

Coming back, sober

Passing away is the summit of the road, but not its end. Of the traveller who reaches it, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, "That's the beginning, that's not the end." Most mystics may never reach this station. Those who do still face dangers, because nearness to God is not safety. Satan once stood near to God, in a place where pride had no room, and there he grew proud. He fell, defeated by nothing but his own self.

Not everyone who passes away comes back well. The lectures describe three ways of going wrong. Let's take them as principles rather than as the stories of particular people.

In the first, the traveller stays lost. Drawn to the divine light, he is held for ever by the beauty of God and does not come back to himself. Such mystics are a small minority. Souls differ in how they meet so great an encounter, as two people caught in the same accident may come out of it in different states.

In the second, the traveller is held only for a while, and in that time he loses control of his tongue. He utters ecstatic sayings (*shath*), words in which he confuses himself with God. While he is out of his mind, he is not held to religious duties, like anyone who has lost his reason. Some mystics go further and say that duties are lifted for ever from one who reaches this station, even once he is in his right mind. The lectures hold this to be unacceptable, above all in the Shia understanding of mysticism, and in most of Sunni mysticism as well.

In the third, and the most dangerous, the traveller can no longer tell himself from his Lord, or his Lord from His creation. He falls into licence

[76] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

and says that "whatever sin is done is done by God". ʿAllama Tabataba'i warns of the same dangers, the "claim of incarnation and identification with God, denial of being obligated to abide by religious injunctions and regarding everything lawful", though he places them earlier on the road, at the stages of remembrance[77].

Most who fall into the worst of these dangers, licence, got there by rushing. They pushed themselves to this station in haste through the wrong kind of practice. Their souls then grew out of proportion, like a body whose head grows huge while the rest stays small. A traveller who practises in a balanced way is raised to the station gradually. The law, a guide, and a measured pace keep him on that way. Chapters Six, Seven, Nine, and Ten set them out. The tradition remembers Bayazid Bistami for his ecstatic sayings and Junayd of Baghdad for the sober way; Chapter Fourteen returns to both[78].

A traveller who has walked at the right pace comes back well. The mystics liken passing away to intoxication (*sukr*). The healthy return they call sobriety after obliteration (*sahw baʿd al-mahw*), or separation after unification (*farq baʿd al-jamʿ*). The traveller who thought himself one with God in passing away gradually comes to tell himself apart from God, and God apart from His creation. Imam Khomeini describes the return as God's grace, which "comes to his aid, bringing him to himself and returning him to the domain of his own self, whereat he finds himself in the state of awakening (sahw)"[79].

This sobriety is not a step down. Murtada Mutahhari writes that the return to remaining (*baqa'*) is not "a retrogression from a higher state", and calls sobriety "loftier even than mahw and mahq" (the effacement and obliteration of passing away)[80]. The Imams (as) lived in it. ʿAllama Tabataba'i's lectures say that they reached "the station of subsistence after annihilation", a state "which combines the two realms of Unity and plurality", and that they never held back from "observance of the most minor of the laws"[81].

In this sobriety neither God nor creation veils the other. For us, creation veils God from our sight, and we see the world without seeing Him. In passing

[77] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 102.
[78] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 25, 27.
[79] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 515.
[80] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 57.
[81] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 60.

away, God's glory veils creation, and the traveller sees only Him. In the return, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "neither of them is veiled by the other". Sayyid Haydar Amuli quotes a gnostic on the same balance. Seeing only unity leads to heresy, whereas seeing only separation denies that God is the Absolute Actor. Both are ways of seeing and not a union of God and creature. The one who holds the two together, the gnostic says, has true affirmation[82].

Passing away is therefore a beginning, and its healthy end is the return. Love carries the traveller to the loss of the false self before God's glory, and grace brings him back sober, seeing God in all things while remaining himself. For us the many things of creation are a veil that hides God. Imam Khomeini writes that for those who have come back they are a mirror of His epiphany, and he shows it with a saying of Imam ʿAli (as)[83].

> *I did not see a thing without beholding God with it, in it, before it, and after it.*[84]
>
> Imam ʿAli (as)

Others have walked this far. Where did the road come from, and who walked it first?

➤ TRY THIS

Sheikh Bahmanpour asks his listeners to notice the word *Huwa*, "He", wherever it appears in the Qur'an, which uses it for God in a striking way. When you recite Surah al-Ikhlas in salah this week, stop for a moment on the word after "Say", *Huwa*. Recall the prayer Imam ʿAli (as) learned from Khidr before Badr, which calls on God by this word, and let it point to Him alone before you go on to "Allah, the One".

[82] Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 116.
[83] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, pp. 515–516.
[84] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 516.